Discourse Analysis

Radhika Mamidi

Discourse

- Monologue
- Dialogue
- Human-Computer Interaction

Some major topics

- Coherence and Cohesion
- Local and Global Structure
- Micro and Macrostructure
- Discourse/Rhetorical Relations
- Cohesive devices – Connectives, Pronouns
- Ellipsis

Coherence and cohesion

- What makes a text coherent?
- What are the cohesive devices?

Discourses have to have connectivity to be coherent.

Eg. Ram took up a job. Shyam went to university.

Insert because/and/so/but between the sentences and see the connectivity.

Discourse Structure

- Global structure: Overall interpretation of a text (macrostructure)
  - Reductive inferences (reduce the text to a much shorter and manageable summary of main points)
  - Eg. 300 page book summarized in 10 sentences
- Local structure: References between adjacent sentences are understood (microstructure)
  - Elaborative inferences (reading between the lines)
  - Eg. Tomorrow is my sister's birthday. I must go shopping
- When we read a book, we keep elaborating mentally (by bridging more between the sentences).
- Unless we understand the text fully, we cannot summarise.

Inferences

- Bridging inferences – to interpret the meanings of utterances.

  I walked into the exam hall. The students looked tense.
- Inference about the reference of given information (Given-New contract)

  The lecture will be in SH-2.
- Inferences about spatial relations

  Susan was inside/outside her house when the child ran out and hugged her.
- Causal inference

  John was murdered yesterday. The knife lay nearby.

Mary left the party when John started dancing with Susan.

When = social relationship related; When = temporal

Audience design

- The intention of the speaker is to make the listener understand his/her utterances.
- Utterances are never meant to be understood in isolation.
- Understanding is always based on the assumption that speaker and listener share some mutual knowledge and beliefs.
- Listeners make bridging inferences based on their shared knowledge (design assumption) with the speaker.

Discourse structure

- Frames
- Schemas
- Goals and plans
- Scripts
- Story grammar

Helps in bridging inference - understanding even though some information is missing or unavailable.

John ordered a sandwich. He was disappointed. He left no tip.

[Restaurant script helps in bridging inferences]

John proposed to Mary last week. The wedding is next month. I am so excited.

[Knowledge of courtship/wedding helps in bridging inferences]

Schema theory

- Understand/Inferences/assumptions
- Bartlett – 1932
- Human memory – high level structures
  - Schemas
    - Template
- Marvin Minsky – 1977
  - Frames, Scenarios
- Roger Schank – 1977
  - script - SAM

Types of schemas that help to infer

- Actions – riding a bicycle

  "Mary bought a new cycle. She fell down" Result

- Events – going to café, birthday, wedding

  "Tomorrow is my sister's birthday. I need to go to the mall today". Purpose

- Situations – work from home

  "I have a meeting now. Can you cut the vegetables?"

- Categories – birds/animals/furniture items

  "I saw a bird sitting on my window"

  "Mary bought a new chair… (for her grandfather/office/saloon)

Sample discourse texts

News article: **Robin Dhowan takes over as Navy chief**

India finally has a new Navy chief. Admiral Rabinder Kumar Dhowan, the vice-chief till Wednesday, took over the reins of the maritime force on Thursday.

After dithering for over 50 days following Admiral DK Joshi's sudden resignation on February 26, owning "moral responsibility" for a string of warship mishaps, the government finally moved swiftly on Thursday to appoint Admiral Robin Dhowan as the new chief.

Admiral Dhowan, who will have a 25-month tenure, has superseded Vice-Admiral Shekhar Kumar Sinha, the current Western Naval Command chief, to become India's 22nd Navy chief.

Of the three vice-admirals who were in the fray, Sinha was commissioned in June 1974, Dhowan in January 1975 and Eastern Naval Command chief Anil Chopra in July 1975.

Structure of joke

- A joke consists of two parts: the set-up and the punch line.
- These two are linked by a ‘surprise element’.
- The joke is carried on two planes – with the listener understanding one plane only initially.
- The punch line triggers the second plane.
- This unexpected switch causes laughter.

Simple jokes

Boy (*in a romantic mood*): Say something soft and sweet.
Girl: Custard pudding.

Peter: I thought of you all day yesterday.
Ross: Really! Where were you?
Peter: At the zoo.

Boy (*offering sweets*): Sweets for the sweet.
Girl: Here, have some nuts.

Peter: You are such a nice person.
Ross: I wish I could say the same for you.
Peter: You can – if you are as big a liar as I am.

Recipes - **Baked Macaroni and Cheese**

INGREDIENTS:

- 1 (16 ounce) package elbow macaroni
- 1/2 cup evaporated milk
- 2 eggs
- 1 (8 ounce) container sour cream
- 1 teaspoon seasoning salt

DIRECTIONS:

1.Preheat oven to 350 degrees F (175 degrees C).

2.Bring a large pot of lightly salted water to a boil. Add pasta and cook for 8 to 10 minutes or until al dente; drain and rinse with cold water.

3.In a bowl mix milk, eggs, sour cream, seasoning salt, and pepper. Layer macaroni, cheddar cheese, and milk mixture until pan is full. Sprinkle Parmesan cheese and pour melted butter on top.

4.Bake in a preheated oven for 20 to 30 minutes or until milk mixture is done.

Excerpt from movie review – Bhoothnath Returns

- ***Bhoothnath Returns* starts off with a fascinating premise but drags towards the end, says Sukanya Verma.**

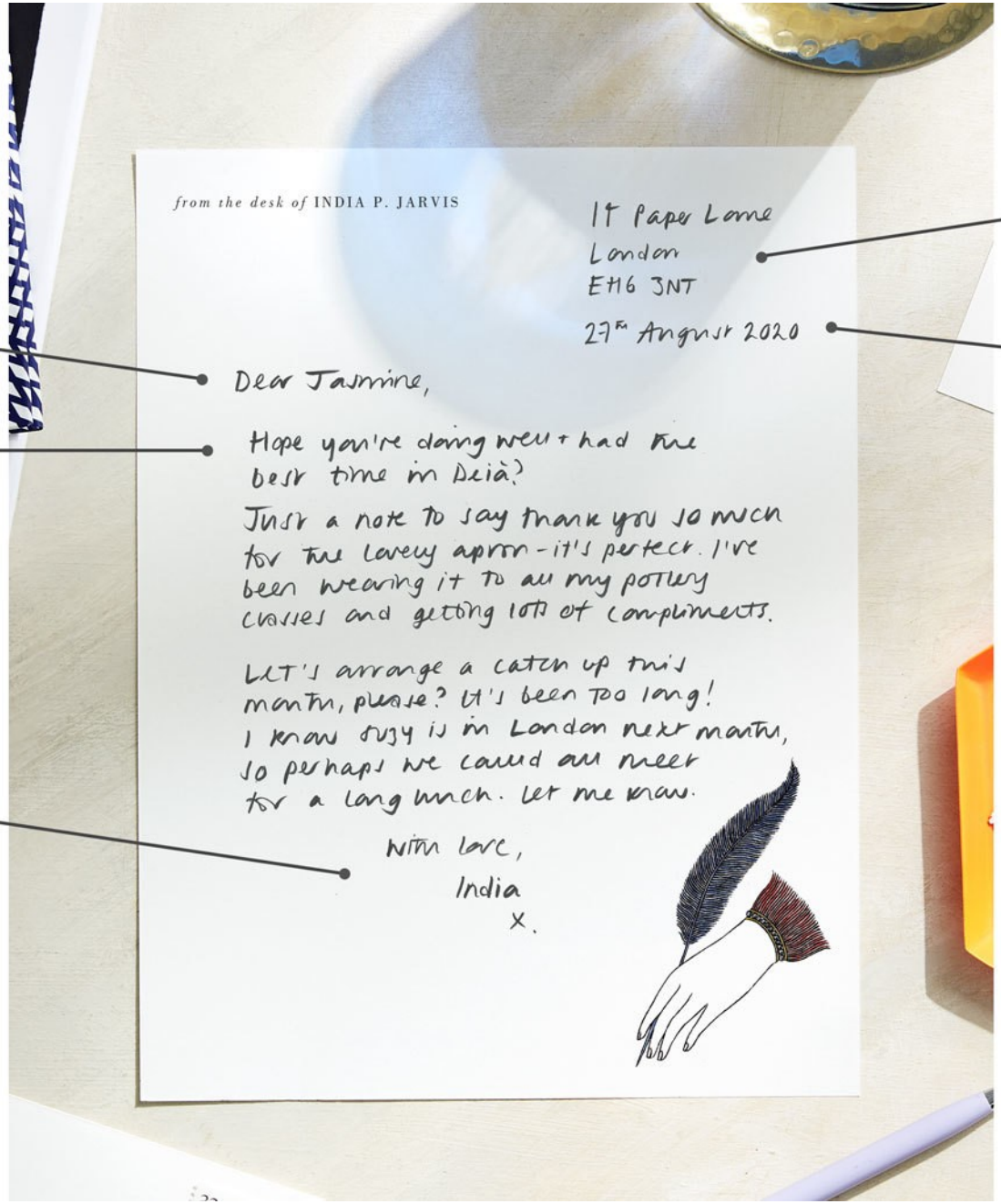
  A conscientious ghost decides to contest elections opposite a criminal candidate and seeks mandate from the gullible public while emphasising on how a worthy candidate shouldn't be judged by the nature of his existence but by his scruples and merit.

  A dead man versus a dead conscience -- fascinating premise for satire or spoof, isn't it?

  Moreover, with election fever in full swing, *Bhoothnath Returns*, directed by Nitesh Tiwari, could not have asked for a better timing.

  The problem with this well-intentioned social drama is that it starts out as a children's film but decides to grow up mid-way and discard its predecessor's endearing traits to take a sanctimonious stand in a regrettably tedious manner.

  Bhoothnath, modelled around *The Canterville Ghost*, wasn't particularly spectacular but genuine enough to work.


from the desk of INDIA P. JARVIS
11 Paper Lane
London
E116 3NT
27th August 2020
Dear Jasmine,
Hope you're doing well + had the best time in Deià?
Just a note to say thank you so much for the lovely apron - it's perfect. I've been wearing it to all my pottery classes and getting lots of compliments.
Let's arrange a catch up this month, please? It's been too long! I know Suzy is in London next month, so perhaps we could all meet for a long lunch. Let me know.
With love,
India
x.
Sender address
Date goes here
Greeting
Body
Sign off

PHYLIS FLEX

GRAPHIC DESIGNER

CONTACT

123-456-7890

hello@reallygreatsite.com

www.reallygreatsite.com

PROFILE

Assists the department head in carrying out digital marketing campaigns works closely with the marketing head for digital promotions and others. Develop and maintain graphical standards, templates, and resources.

EDUCATION

Masters in Product Design
San Dias University
2019-2021

BA Product Design
San Dias University
2015-2019

SKILLS

PROFESSIONAL

Time management

Problem solving

Communication

Creativity

Leadership

Quick learner

Leadership

Problem solving

EXPERIENCE

ART DIRECTOR

Really Great Company | 2023

- Comes up with unique graphic designs for clients.
- Brainstorms innovative ideas for the company's portfolio.
- Works closely with the copywriting team.

PROJECT MANAGER

Really Great Company | 2025

- Edited editorial photos for clients and magazines
- Increase lift for existing packages in varied lines of business.
- Tasked to make graphics for online layouts.
- Concept and develop control beaters
- Organization of files

PROJECT MANAGER

Really Great Company | 2027

- Worked on marketing campaigns for different brands.
- Handled multiple digital accounts.
- Created digital marketing campaigns for brands.
- Assisted the head designer in numerous projects

[Your Name]

Objective

Education

Experience

Awards & Acknowledgements

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CREATIVE AGENCY

Single Pager for Mayor Candidate Campaign Flyer

This one page covers the one pager for mayor candidate election flyer campaign along with candidate details and voting date.

VOTE

DR. LENORA EDWARDS

Voting Date -27th December 2020

FOR MAYOR

"Giving You What You Need."

Dr. Lenora is an American politician who was a mayor of Flint, Michigan during 2015 to 2019. She is a member of democratic party.

Mon to Fri
11 AM TO 5 PM

Address: 877 East Highway, Suite 3400, Silver Spring, MD 20910

Telephone: 866-747-1471
Email-Lenora@abc.us

Dr. Lenora Edwards
@drlenoraedwards

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വിവാഹത്തിന്റെ പുണ്യ സന്ദർഭത്തിൽ
നിങ്ങളുടെ കൃപാവരത്തെ ഞങ്ങൾ ഹൃദ്യമായി
ക്ഷണിക്കുന്നു
രാജേഷ്
(എസ് / ഒ ശ്രീമതി കമലദേവി ഷെട്ടി & ശ്രീ വിക്രം
ഷെട്ടി, കേരളം)
Weds
പ്രിയങ്ക
(ഡി / ഒ ശ്രീമതി വിദ്യ അയ്യർ & ശ്രീ രാകേഷ് അയ്യർ,
കേരളം)
കല്യാണം: - ജനുവരി 18 വെള്ളിയാഴ്ച,
രാവിലെ 9.30 രാവിലെ
❊ വേദി ❊
ലക്ഷ്മി വിവാഹ ഹാൾ, കേരളം
❊ അയച്ചയാളുടെ പേര് ❊
രാകേഷ് അയ്യറും കുടുംബവും
ഫോൺ: 91-0000000000

మలిశెట్టి వారి కళ్యాణ శుభలేఖ
అచ్చుత సత్యనారాయణ-లక్ష్మి
వాయినందన ప్రెస్ వీధి - కావలి
మా మేనల్లుడు
చి॥ సురేష్
(కీ.శే. మలిశెట్టి శ్రీనివాసులు - శ్రీమతి పద్మావతి గార్ల కనిష్ట పుత్రుడు)
చి॥ల॥సౌ॥ సుప్రజ
(శ్రీ చిన్ని రవీంద్రకుమార్ - శ్రీమతి వాణి గార్ల ఏకైక పుత్రిక,నెల్లూరు.)
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వివాహము
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తమ ఆగమనాభిలాషులు:
మలిశెట్టి సతీష్ - శ్రావణి
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కార్యనిర్వాహకులు : బంధుమిత్రులు.
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PROGRAMME

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Prahar by Aakruti Kathak Kendra (Kathak Group)

18th December

Shri Ramaprapanna Bhattacharya (Sitar) accompanied by Shri Amit Bhushan (Tabla)

Shri Abhimanyu Lal (Kathak Solo)

Smt. Malti Shyam (Kathak Solo)

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ALL ARE INVITED

Schemas

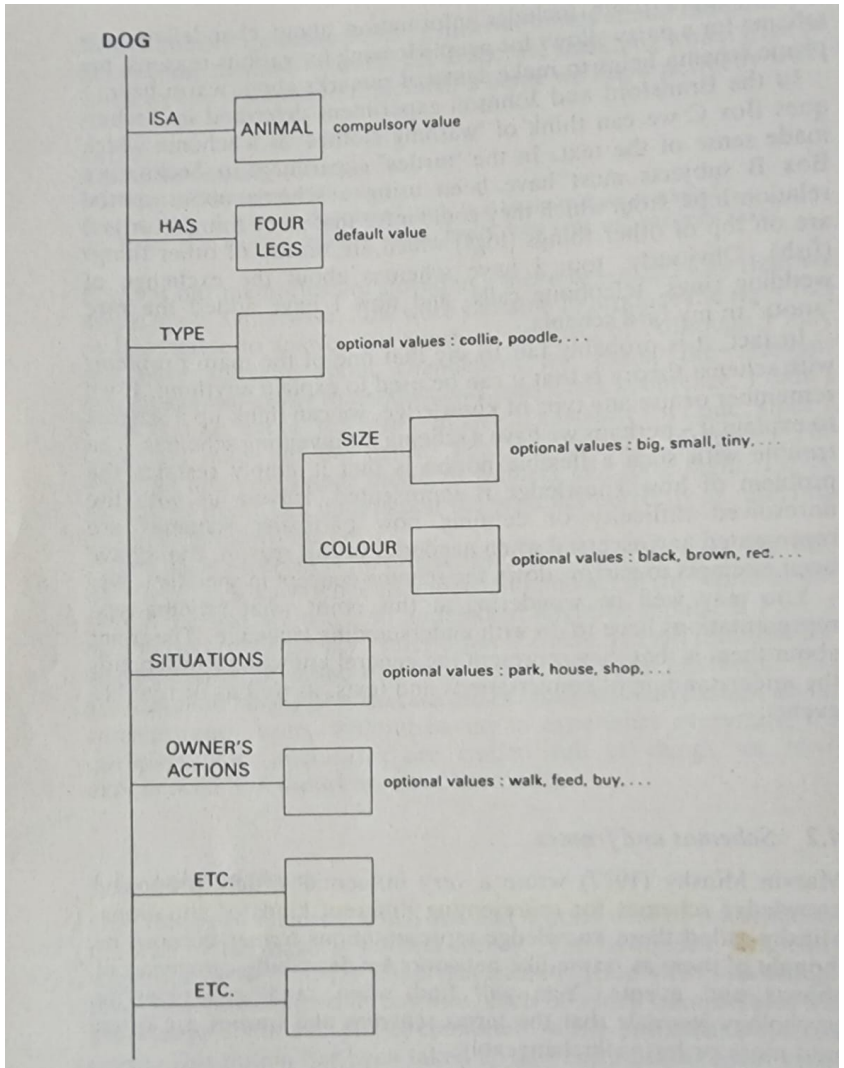


Figure 1.1 A 'dog' frame

Schemas represented as frames.
Slots cover large information
Compulsory and optional values

Inferences are made for probable slot values.
If information is lacking, we fill with default values.

"I see a dog outside".

Practice: chair, elephant, house

Name: Restaurant

Props: Tables
Menu
Food
Bill
Money
Tip

Roles: Customer
Waiter/waitress
Cook
Cashier
Owner

Entry conditions: Customer is hungry
Customer has money

Results: Customer has less money
Owner has more money
Customer is not hungry

Scene 1: Entering
Customer enters restaurant
Customer looks for table
Customer decides where to sit
Customer goes to table
Customer sits down

Scene 2: Ordering
Waitress brings menu
Customer reads menu
Customer decides on food
Customer orders food
Waitress gives food order to cook
Cook prepares food

Scene 3: Eating
Cook gives food to waitress
Waitress brings food to customer
Customer eats food

Scene 4: Exiting
Customer asks for bill
Waitress gives bill to customer
Customer gives tip to waitress
Customer goes to cashier
Customer gives money to cashier
Customer leaves restaurant

Figure 1.9 Restaurant script (adapted from Bower, Black and Turner, 1979)

John went to a fast-food café. He ordered a sandwich. He was disappointed. He left no tip.

Inferences on John's behaviour (why he left no tip) based on the restaurant script.

1.Elaborative inference

Assume all the subevents took place.

2. Slot-filling

Customer: John
Restaurant: fast-food café
Customer enters restaurant: John went to a fast-food café.
Customer orders food: John ordered a sandwich
Food: Disappointing (based on bridging inference)

3. Restrictive inference

Customer is not hungry while exiting but John is hungry when leaving the café. That is why he left no tip.

Practice: Travelling by train, Waiting room, Hospital visit

Mandler's (1984) idealized story grammar

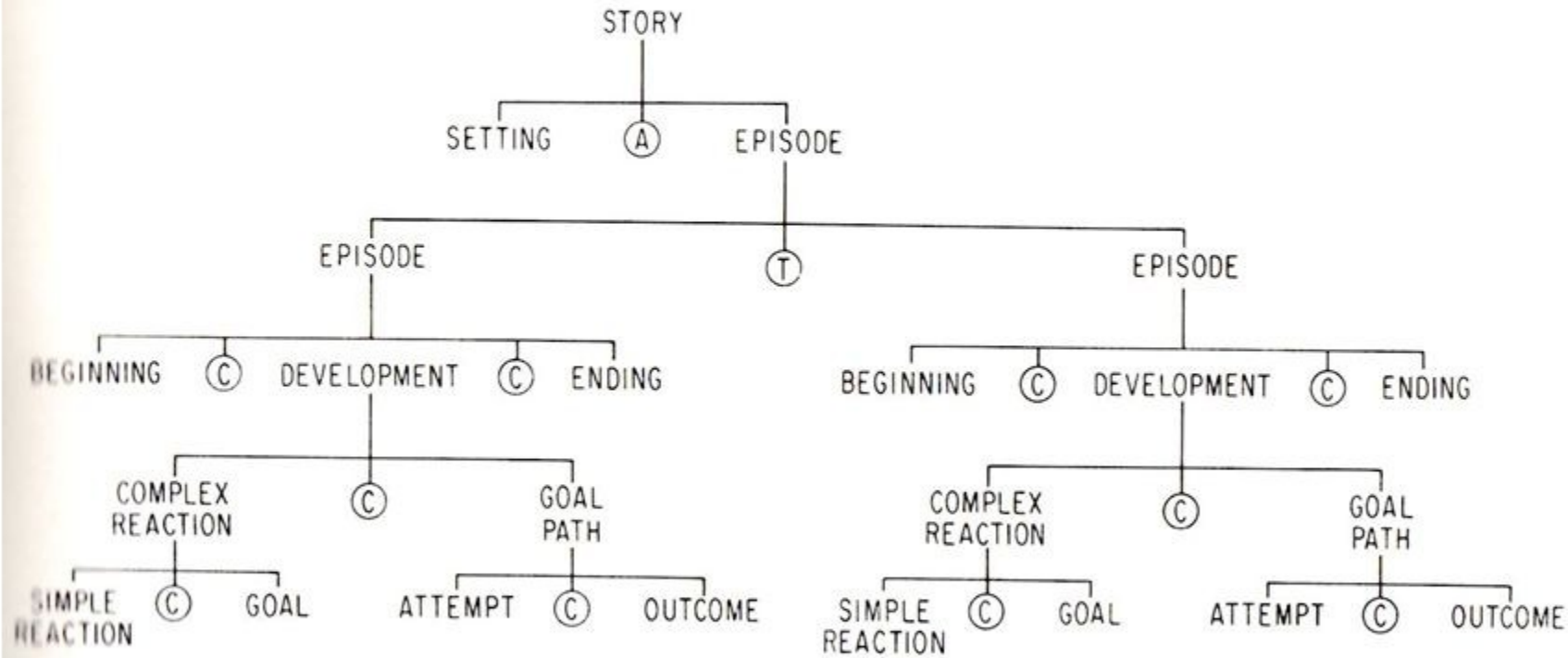


FIG. 2 A representation of the underlying structure of a simple two-episode story, such as that shown in Table 2. The *and, then,* and *cause* relations are represented by A, T, and C, respectively.

Story grammar – Thorndyke (1977)

- Story – Setting, Theme, Plot, Resolution
- Setting – characters, location, time
- Theme – Goal
- Plot – Episode(s)
- Episode – subgoal + attempts + outcome
- Attempt – Event(s)
- Resolution – Event and/or State
- Goal – Desired state

Rule number	Rule
1	STORY → SETTING + THEME + PLOT + RESOLUTION
2	SETTING → CHARACTERS + LOCATION + TIME
3	THEME → GOAL
4	PLOT → EPISODE(S)
5	EPISODE → SUBGOAL + ATTEMPT(S) + OUTCOME
6	ATTEMPT → EVENT(S)
7	RESOLUTION → EVENT and/or STATE
8	GOAL → DESIRED STATE

Figure 1.6 Grammar rules for simple stories (adapted from Thorndyke, 1977)

Let us take a simple story as an example (each phrase in the story is identified by a number):

Once upon a time (1) a prince and princess (2) were walking in the forest (3). The prince wanted to marry the princess (4). He asked her to marry him (5). She said yes (6). They got married and lived happily ever after (7).

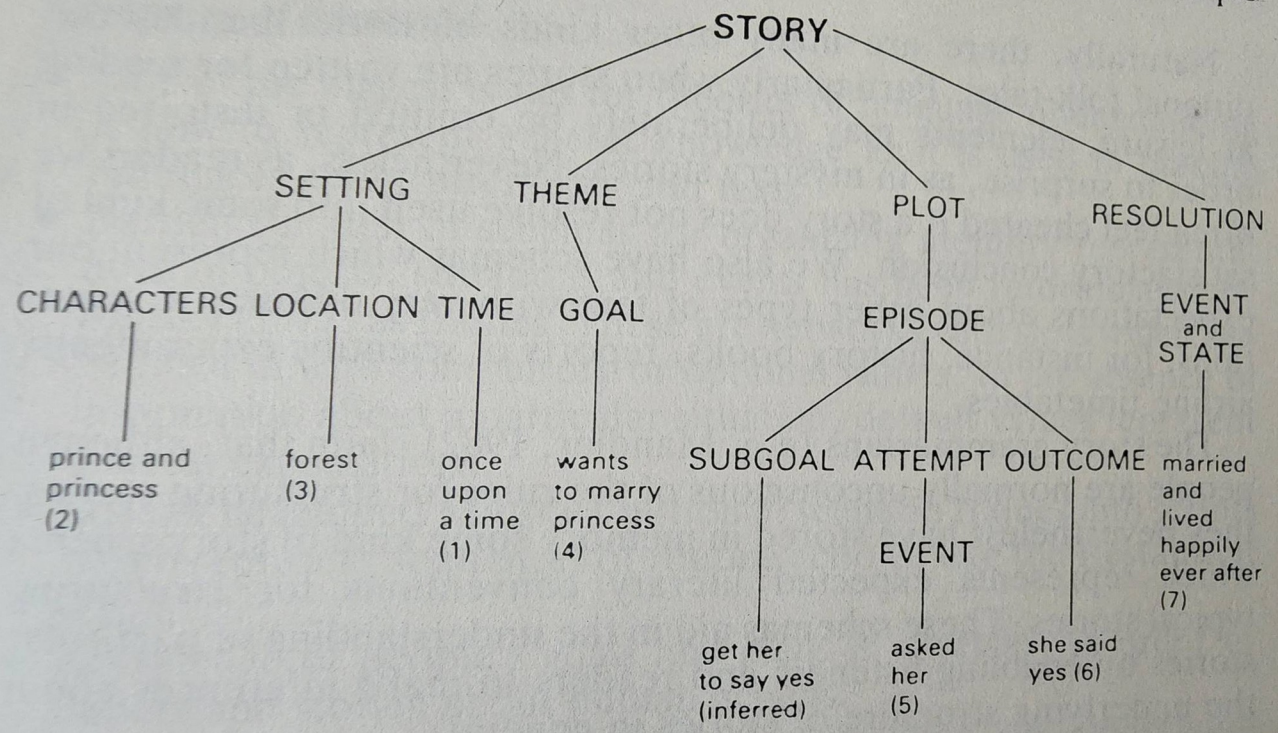
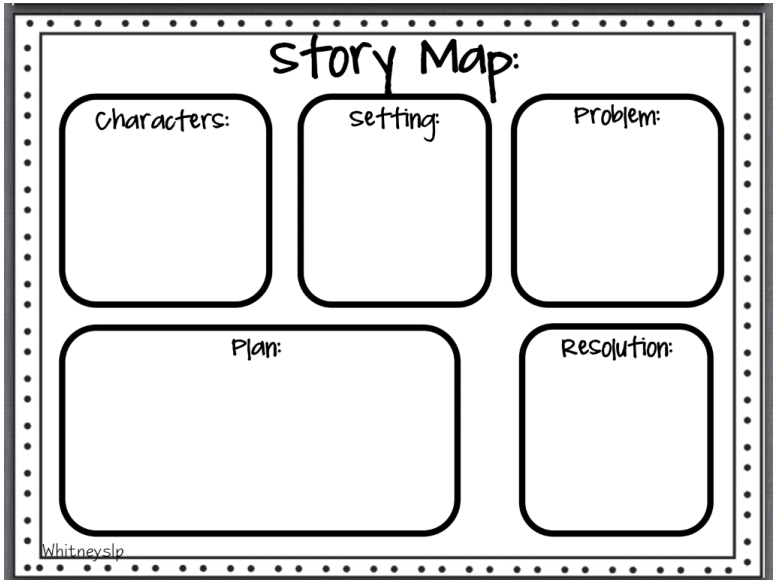
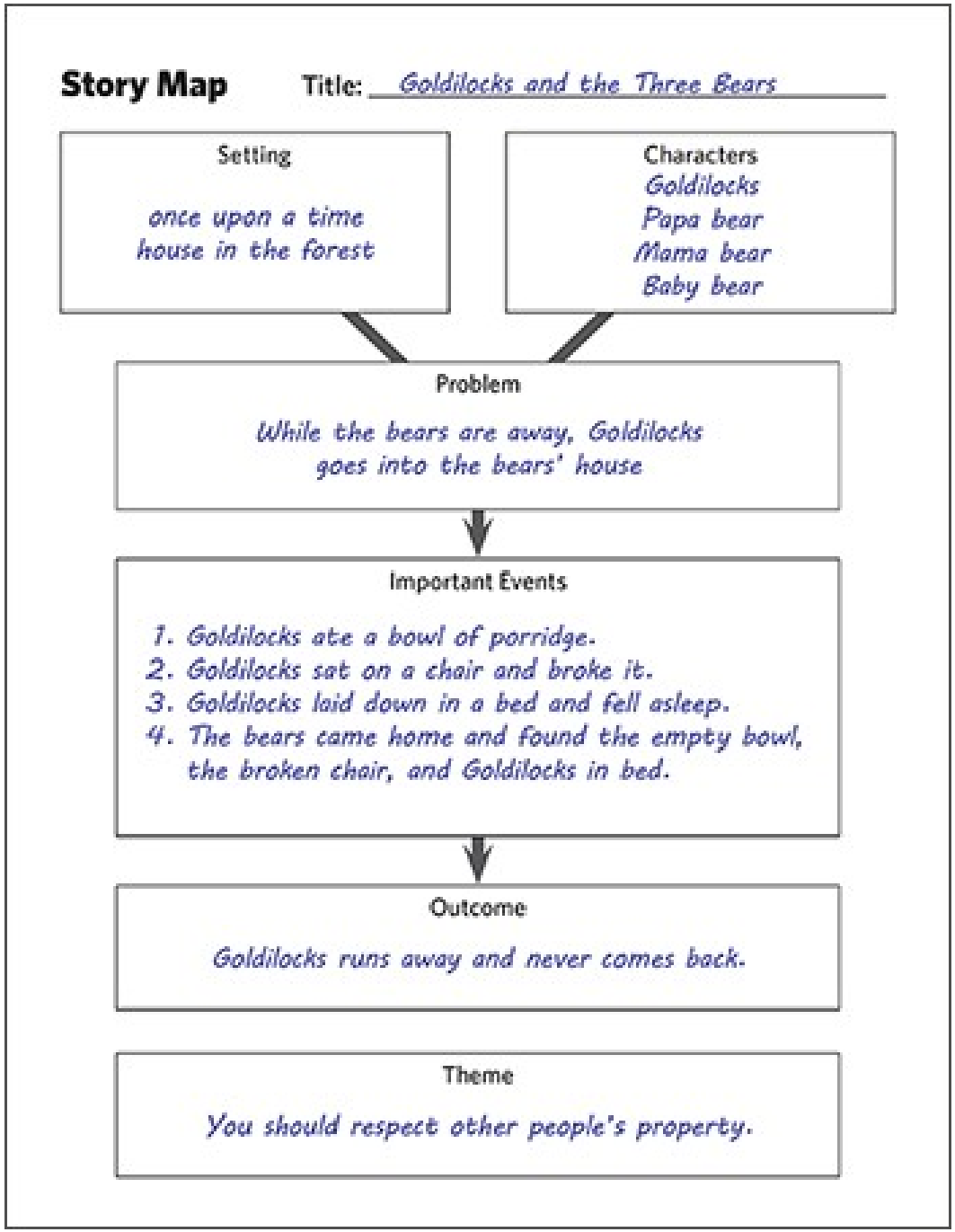
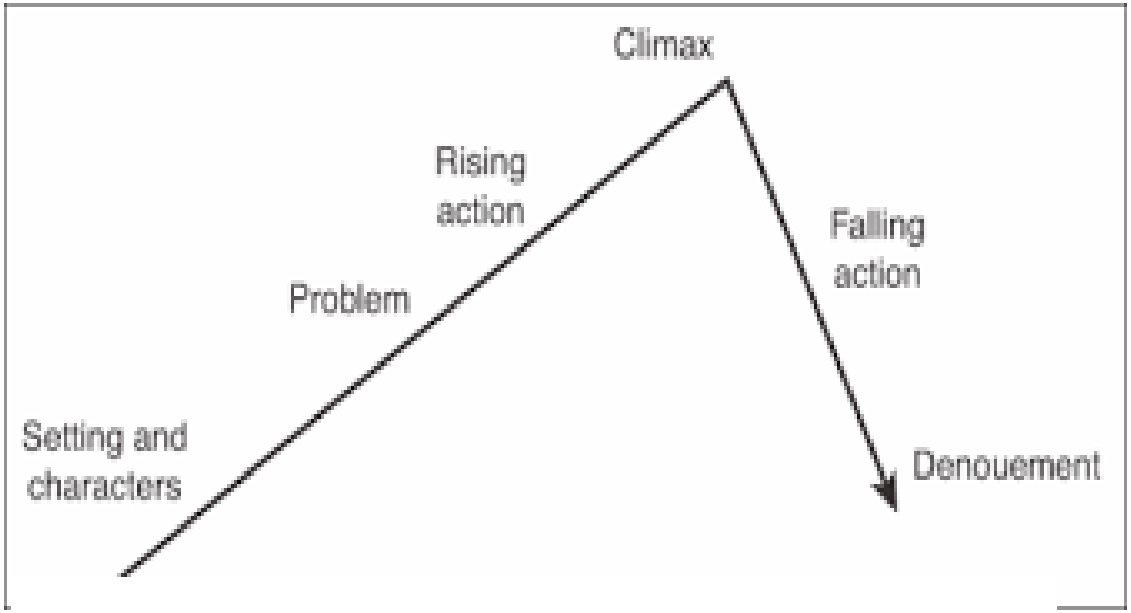


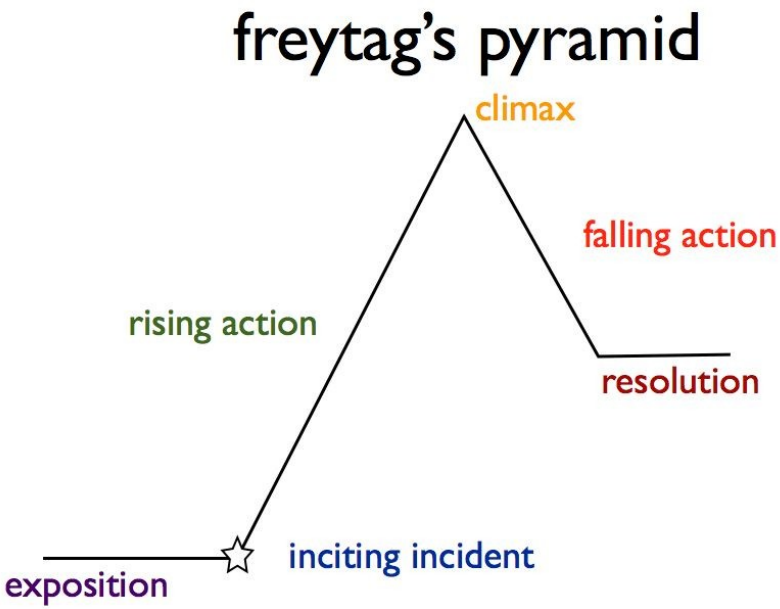
Figure 1.7 Tree structure for a simple story

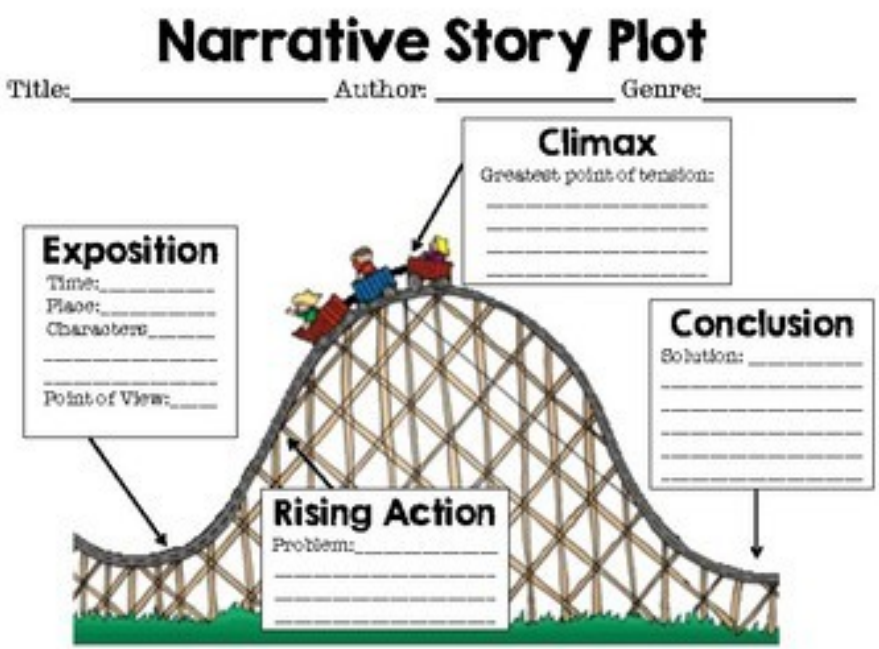


Practice: Think of a story and come up with story grammar and story map.




Climax
Rising action
Falling action
Problem
Setting and characters
Denouement


freytag's pyramid
climax
falling action
rising action
resolution
inciting incident
exposition


Narrative Story Plot
Title:
Author:
Genre:
Climax
Greatest point of tension:
Exposition
Time:
Place:
Characters:
Point of View:
Conclusion
Solution:
Rising Action
Problem:

Conversational structure

Opening

Turn taking management

Closing

For a coherent interaction:

Understanding intention→ Correct inference
(of the speaker) (by the hearer)

- Given any utterance, its speech act can play a role in many plans.
- "Do you know the time?"

. . . goal of learning the time

. . . goal of hurrying up the hearer

. . . scolding for being late, etc.

[Sentence meaning vs Speaker meaning: Sperber & Wilson]

Two important aspects

- Recognise intention of speaker
  - A1: Lend me your umbrella. It is cloudy. [Request]
  - A2: Don't water the plants now. It is cloudy. [Warning]
  - A3: It will rain today. It is cloudy. [Assertion]
  - A4: I hope the pictures will come out well. It is cloudy. [Doubt]

- Make proper inference (Eg. Detect sarcasm)
  - B1: Did you look at the sentence I sent you to translate.
  - C1: Yeah. It was such an easy sentence!
  - B2: Was it easy?
  - C2: No, I meant it was tough.

CASE I:

Speaker A: nenu cinemaki vellali.

Translation: I have to go to the movies.

Speaker B: aa table mida cash undi tisko.

Translation: There is money on that table. Take it.

CASE II:

Speaker A: reyy market ki vastava ?

Translation: Hey, Do you want to come to the market?

Speaker B: nenu cinemaki vellali.

Translation: I have to go to the movies.

Conversation Analysis

- Turn Constructional Component Turns composed of one or more smaller utterance units
- Turn Allocational Component Self and other selection
- Sequence Organization
- Adjacency pairs: greeting-greeting, question-answer pairs
  - Preferred, Dispreferred 2nd parts
- Pre-sequences
- Preference Organisation:

  agreement and acceptance are promoted over their alternatives
- Repair:

  who initiates repair (self or other) and by who resolves the problem (self or other)

Sacks, H., Schegloff, E. A., & Jefferson, G. (1974)

Conversational analysis

- Turn management: determining when the turn is over and who talks next; turn taking organisation
- Grounding: acknowledgement, repetition
- Clarification: question to resolve some lack of understanding
- Confirmation: answering in affirmation to a query
- Utterances in a dialogue acting as a pair; adjacency pairs

Turn Taking organisation

- Turn offer
- Turn accept
- Turn reject
- Turn continue
- Turn grab
- Turn keep
- Turn assign

Adjacency pairs

- call/beckon → response

"*Waiter!*" → "*Yes, sir*"

- complaint → excuse/remedy

"*It's awfully cold in here*" → "*Oh, sorry, I'll close the window*"

- compliment → acceptance/refusal

"*I really like your new haircut!!*" → "*Oh, thanks*"

- degreeting → degreeting

"*See you!*" → "*Yeah, see you later!*"

- inform → acknowledge

"*Your phone is over there*" → "*I know*"

- greeting → greeting

"*Hiya!*" → "*Oh, hi!*"

- offer → acceptance/rejection

"*Would you like to visit the museum with me this evening?*" → "*I'd love to!*"

- question → answer

"*What does this big red button do?*" → "*It causes two-thirds of the universe to implode*"

- request → acceptance/rejection

  "*Is it OK if I borrow this book?*" → "*I'd rather you didn't, it's due back at the library tomorrow*"

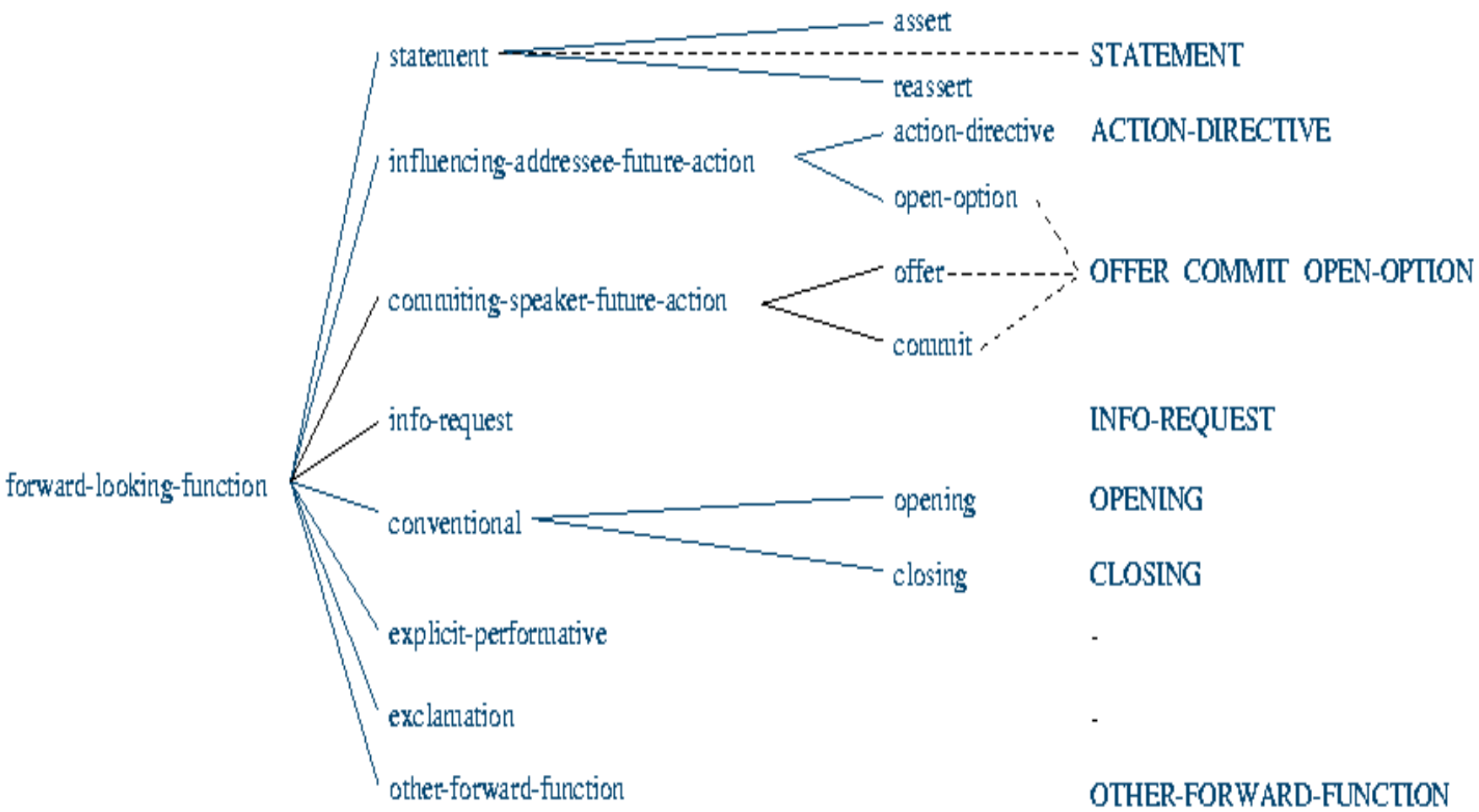
- blame --> denial/affirm

you left the lights on" --> "*It wasn't me*"

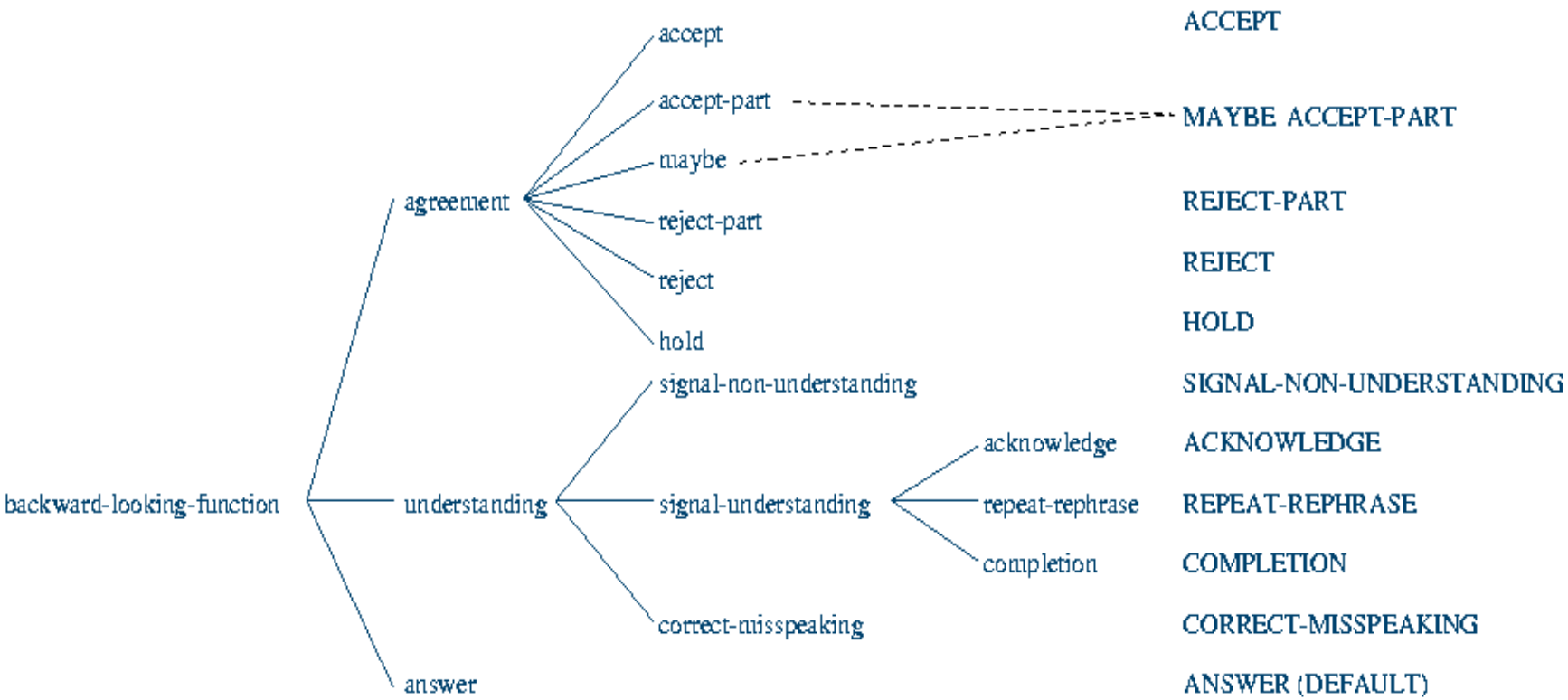
DAMSL Annotation Schema

- **Communicative-Status**
  - Uninterpretable, Abandoned, Self-talk
- **Information-Level**
  - Task (``Doing the task'')
  - Task-management (``Talking about the task'')
  - Communication-management (``Maintaining the communication'')
  - Other-level
- **Forward Looking function**
- **Backward Looking function**

Forward looking function



Backward looking function



Thank you!